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A preliminary investigation of intentions to engage in academic misconduct using generative artificial intelligence tools

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ABSTRACT

This study was the first to examine student intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs via the Theory of Planned Behavior (Ajzen, I. 1991. The theory of planned behavior. *Organizational Behavior and Human Decision Processes* 50, no. 2: 179–211), in addition to secondary factors pertinent to AI use. A sample of undergraduate students ($N = 186$) completed an online survey investigating student intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs, attitudes towards academic misconduct and AI, subjective norms, perceived behavioral control, and beliefs about the likelihood of detection. Analyses revealed that positive attitudes towards academic misconduct and AI, as well as subjective norms about academic misconduct, were associated with greater intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs, while higher perceived likelihood of GAIT detection was related to lower intention. These findings highlight the need for targeted institutional strategies addressing the factors associated with increased intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs, alongside current efforts to seamlessly integrate responsible AI use within higher education.

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The growing popularity of Artificial Intelligence (AI) has led to gross technological advancements across numerous domains, including education, healthcare, transportation, communication, and finance (Khalil and Er 2023). However, amidst the numerous benefits, there are robust concerns about the impact of AI on academic integrity, particularly within tertiary education (Parnter 2022). Despite there being extensive research aimed at better understanding and explaining academic misconduct, violations of academic integrity remain highly prevalent across student bodies within higher education settings (M. Birks et al. 2020). Unfortunately, the introduction of Generative AI tools (GAITs), while offering many opportunities to assist and support the learning process, has simultaneously afforded students a new avenue for engaging in academic misconduct.

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GAITs are artificial intelligence systems that can generate novel content, such as text, images, and other forms of media (Salvagno, Taccone, and Gerli 2023). The emergence of this technology has placed significant pressure on tertiary institutions to develop methods to manage their use in the context of academic misconduct. However, the existing literature predominantly focuses on traditional forms of academic misconduct and overlooks specific predictors of academic misconduct using GAITs. To develop solutions for management, it is first necessary to explore and understand who is most likely to use GAITs to engage in academic misconduct and why. This study aims to address this gap by investigating such behaviors among a sample of undergraduate psychology students through the lens of the Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB; Ajzen 1991), a framework that has been rigorously applied to academic misconduct, but not yet in the context of breaches of academic integrity using GAITs. The TPB posits that three factors – attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control – are predictive of the intention to engage in a certain behavior, which in turn forecasts engagement in the behavior itself (Ajzen 1991). Extending beyond the TPB, the role of two other factors known to influence decisions about AI use were also of interest to this study; namely, attitudes towards AI and perceived likelihood of detection of GAIT use in university settings.

Generative AI tools (GAITs)

GAITs are artificial intelligence systems that can generate new content, such as images, text, audio, music, and videos (Salvagno, Taccone, and Gerli 2023). Popular examples of such tools include ChatGPT, Microsoft Copilot, DALL-E, and Google Gemini. GAITs offer many benefits, including but not limited to the ability to facilitate social interactions and enhance student learning (Bozkurt et al. 2023). However, their capacity to generate academic content, such as in the context of traditional assessment paradigms (e.g. written assignments, essays, reports, etc.), has raised concerns about their potential use for academic misconduct, including plagiarism and cheating (Bozkurt et al. 2023; Salvagno, Taccone, and Gerli 2023). While earlier research focused on misuse of GAITs and the limitations of AI detection technologies (Dalalah and Dalalah 2023; Köbis and Mossink 2021), recent attention has shifted towards promoting responsible and transparent use, recognizing that detection alone is insufficient for safeguarding academic integrity (An, Yu, and James 2025; Ardito 2025; Dalalah and Dalalah 2023; Perkins et al. 2023; Peterson 2025; Weber-Wulff et al. 2023). Within this evolving landscape and apparent increase in the ease of engaging in academic misconduct, it is important that educational institutions shift their focus from a parochial emphasis on AI detection to fostering an understanding of the motivations driving these behaviors. Though empirical work on motivations for academic misconduct in the context of GAITs is still emerging, broader research pertaining to the reasons why students engage in traditional academic misconduct is suggestive.

Academic misconduct

Academic misconduct refers to behaviors that violate academic integrity, resulting in unfair academic advantages (Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2010). Traditional forms of academic misconduct include plagiarism, cheating, fabrication of data, unauthorized collaboration,

and contract cheating (Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2010). There is substantial evidence that academic misconduct remains a prevalent issue among students in tertiary institutions (M. Birks et al. 2020). For example, in Australia, Curtis and Popal (2011) reported plagiarism rates as high as 74%, and found that 7.9% of Australian university students utilized contract cheating services, while 11.4% resorted to obtaining pre-written work.

Students may engage in academic misconduct for a number of reasons including peer pressure, perceptions of cheating as the norm, confusion about what constitutes academic misconduct, ignorance as to the boundaries of acceptable academic practices, high academic expectations, intense competition, and a fear of failure (Bayaa Martin Saana et al. 2016; Miles, Campbell, and Ruxton 2022). The growing popularity of online flexible modes of study has further enabled academic misconduct due to the increased relative ease with which this can occur in remote learning environments, relative to more traditional study contexts (Chen and Chou 2017; Miles, Campbell, and Ruxton 2022). The rapid emergence of GAITs presents a new avenue for such behavior. In the context of AI, academic misconduct refers to the use of GAITs that substitutes a students' writing or intellectual contribution, misrepresents authorship, or violates assessment rules regarding originality and permitted assistance (Shaw 2025). This includes, for example, submitting AI-generated work as one's own, using AI where it is prohibited, or failing to acknowledge AI assistance where required (D. Birks and Clare 2023; Shaw 2025).

However, the boundaries of acceptable versus improper AI use are often unclear to students as institutional policies are still evolving and course expectations vary widely. Consequently, students may struggle to distinguish permitted and supportive use from behaviors that constitute academic misconduct (Chan 2025). Importantly, not all AI use is considered misconduct, with many institutions now permitting and encouraging responsible engagement (An, Yu, and James 2025). Thus, improper use of AI is best understood as use that violates stated assessment rules or institutional integrity policies (An, Yu, and James 2025; Shaw 2025). Given the increasing proficiency with which students can produce human-like text using GAITs, understanding the factors that motivate students to use AI in ways that cross these boundaries is essential.

Academic misconduct has significant consequences for students, including assurance of skill development and graduate capabilities, as well as the imposition of severe penalties, such as formal notes on students' academic transcripts, failure or expulsion (Abdollahmohammadi and Baker 2007; Parnter 2022). The consequences also extend to higher education providers, undermining their credibility, devaluing assessments and qualifications, reducing trust in the institution, lowering enrollments, diminishing funding, compromising accreditation, and damaging institutional reputation (Denisova-Schmidt, Prytula, and Rumyantseva 2019; Bertram Gallant, Binkin, and Donohue 2015). Research on how academic misconduct occurs, and how it might be mitigated, must therefore keep pace with advancements in the field and emerging risks to academic integrity, including those posed by GAITs.

The theory of planned behavior: an explanatory model for academic misconduct

The Theory of Planned Behavior (TPB; Ajzen 1991) is a robust framework that has been extensively applied to explain and predict human behavior, including but not limited to

episodes of academic misconduct (e.g. Chudzicka-Czupala et al. 2016; Hendy and Montargot 2019; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2009). It posits three key reciprocally linked predictors of behavioral intention – attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control – which indirectly influence behavior via intention. *Attitudes* refer to an individuals' positive or negative evaluations of a behavior, person, or event (Ajzen 1991). Numerous studies examining traditional forms of academic misconduct consistently demonstrate that favorable attitudes significantly increase the likelihood of engaging in such behaviors (Alleyne and Phillips 2011; Harding et al. 2007; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2009; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2010). Furthermore, Hendy and Montargot (2019) identified attitudes as the strongest predictor of academic dishonesty. Next, *subjective norms* refer to an individuals' perception of the beliefs and expectations of the people important to them (Ajzen 1991). Positive subjective norms significantly predict intentions to engage in academic misconduct, a finding that has been replicated across numerous studies (Alleyne and Phillips 2011; Cronan, Mullins, and Douglas 2018; Harding et al. 2007; Hendy and Montargot 2019; Juan et al. 2022; Maloshonok and Shmeleva 2019; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2009). Finally, *perceived behavioral control* refers to an individuals' belief about how easy or difficult it is to perform a certain behavior (Ajzen 1991). Several studies indicate greater perceived behavioral control predicts stronger intention to engage in academic misconduct (Alleyne and Phillips 2011; Cronan, Mullins, and Douglas 2018; Juan et al. 2022; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2009; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2010). It appears the more capable or enabled a person feels to breach academic integrity, the greater their intent to engage in such behaviors – at least in the context of more traditional forms of academic misconduct. Studies have demonstrated that these three identified predictors account for 21% to 50% of variance in cheating intention, and over 30% for cheating behavior itself (Armitage and Conner 2001; Hendy and Montargot 2019; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2010; Yang et al. 2021). Nonetheless, there exists a gap in literature regarding the application of this model to academic misconduct using GAITs.

Expanding the explanatory model: factors relating to AI use

While the TPB offers potential insight into how it is the student in higher education may come to violate academic integrity policy via the unauthorized use of GAITs, research in the area of more traditional forms of academic misconduct has also begun exploring extensions of the model that may yield more explanatory power (e.g. Imran, Hussien, and Alaraimi 2025; Rajah-Kanagasabai and Roberts 2015; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2010). Accordingly, the relationship between two known determinants of AI use and intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs, over and above contributions from the TPB, were of interest in this study: attitudes towards AI and perceived likelihood of detection of GAIT use.

Attitudes towards AI

Within the TPB, attitudes refer to evaluations about performing a specific behavior, such as engaging in academic misconduct in the context of GAITs. However, a student's actions may be influenced not only by their evaluation of misconduct itself, but also their perspectives on the technology enabling the behavior. Research consistently demonstrates that general attitudes toward a technology can predict acceptance and

use, independent from attitudes towards any given behavior (Martin 2012). This is consistent with the Technology Acceptance Model, which suggests attitudes towards technology are a distinct antecedent of technology use, separate from perspectives on specific behavioral engagement. This distinction supports the consideration of attitudes toward AI as a potential predictor of intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs, beyond the TPB model (Martin 2012).

Multiple studies have demonstrated that individuals who possess positive attitudes towards AI tend to report greater acceptance and use of these technologies (Darda, Carre, and Cross 2023; Katsantonis and Katsantonis 2024; Kim 2019; Lambert et al. 2023; Schepman and Rodway 2020). Interestingly, a study conducted by Darda, Carre, and Cross (2023) has further highlighted that the valence of these attitudes may also be important, finding that positive, but not negative, attitudes towards AI appear to correlate with appreciation for AI-generated texts. It is thus plausible that students possessing more positive attitudes towards AI may also be more accepting of GAITs, and therefore increasingly prone to their use, including for the purposes of committing acts of academic misconduct.

Perceived likelihood of detection

Beliefs about perceived likelihood of detection may play a further role in students' intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs. Unlike perceived behavioral control, which reflects students' beliefs about their own ability to perform a behavior, perceived likelihood of detection refers to an individuals' perception of how likely they are to be caught engaging in a specific behavior (Megehee and Spake 2008), highlighting a complementary but distinct pathway to misconduct intention. According to economic theory, individuals weigh the benefits and costs of a behavior before deciding whether to engage in it (Megehee and Spake 2008). There are many potential perceived benefits of engaging in academic misconduct, including the prospect of better grades, reduced stress, and more time for managing competing commitments (Megehee and Spake 2008; Miles, Campbell, and Ruxton 2022). However, there are also significant negative consequences associated with getting caught, including the application of severe academic penalties (Dalalah and Dalalah 2023; Miles, Campbell, and Ruxton 2022). Deterrence theory similarly posits that individuals are less likely to engage in misconduct when they believe authorities have both the capacity and willingness to detect and sanction such behavior (Ogilvie and Stewart 2010).

Perceptions of detection may be important in the context of GAITs as students often possess limited understanding of how detectable AI-generated text is and may underestimate or overestimate institutional capacity to identify unauthorized use (Ortiz-Bonnin and Blahopoulou 2025). This uncertainty can work to enhance or weaken deterrence and may impact the likelihood of students engaging in improper GAIT use (Choo and Tan 2023). Consistent with this, studies have demonstrated students are likely to avoid acts of academic misconduct when they perceive the likelihood of detection to be high (de Lambert, Ellen, and Taylor 2006; McCabe, Trevino, and Butterfield 2002; Megehee and Spake 2008; Power 2009), presumably due to the high costs seemingly outweighing the benefits of such behaviors. This supports the inclusion of perceived likelihood of detection in models of AI-enabled academic misconduct, as risk perception could influence GAIT use for the purpose of academic misconduct (Ortiz-Bonnin and Blahopoulou 2025).

Present study

The present study aimed to investigate the relationship between university students' intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs and three constructs purported by the TPB to influence behavioral intention; namely attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control. While the existing evidence has demonstrated that the TPB model provides a useful explanatory framework for understanding student intentions to engage in traditional forms of academic misconduct, no studies to date appear to have explored these associations in the context of breaches of academic integrity facilitated by GAITs. Furthermore, the role of other factors, such as attitudes towards AI and perceived likelihood of detection if engaging in academic misconduct, both of which have been linked to more traditional violations of academic integrity, remain unexplored in the context of GAITs. Therefore, a secondary aim of this study was to extend application of Ajzen's (1991) model of the TPB to investigate potential relations between attitudes towards AI, perceived likelihood of detection, and intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs (see Figure 1).

It is worth noting despite the heavy reliance on self-reported measures of academic misconduct within the literature, few if any studies address social desirability bias,

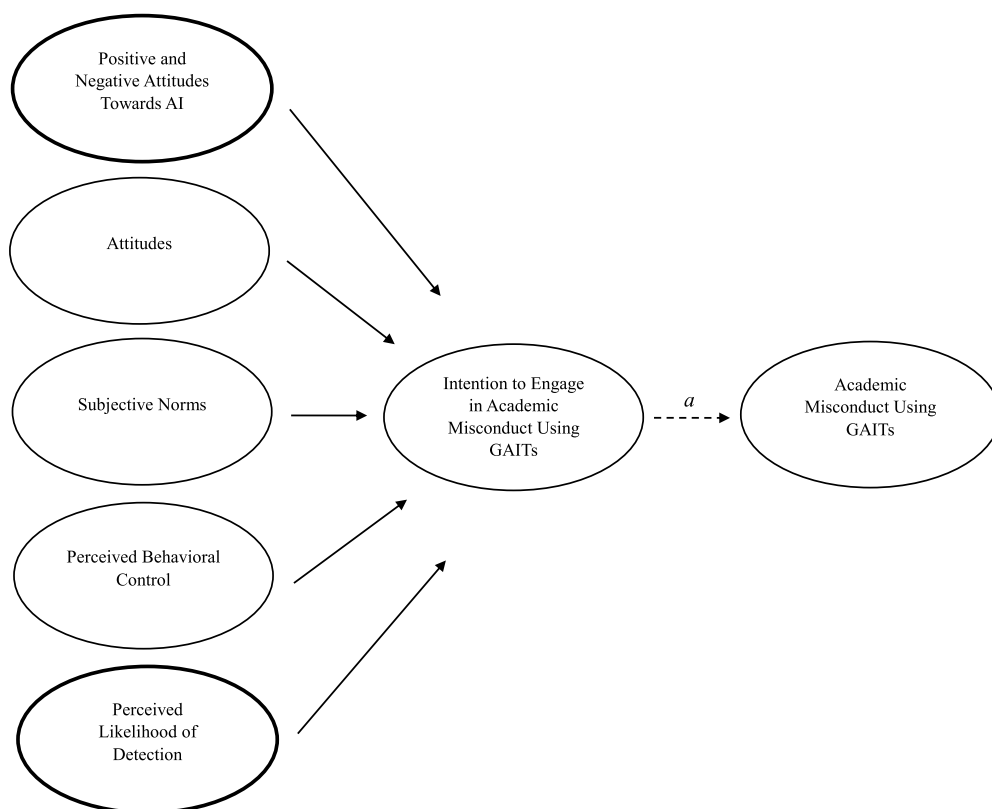


Figure 1. Expanding Ajzen's (1991) theory of planned behavior to understand intentions to engage in academic misconduct in the context of GAITs.

Note: ^aPath was not tested in the present study.

which has been previously acknowledged as a limitation of such research (Imran, Hussien, and Alaraimi 2025; Juan et al. 2022; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2009). As such, participants in the current study were also asked to complete a short measure of social desirability to control for potential bias (Hart et al. 2015; Staats and Hupp 2012). Moreover, as differential relationships have been found for positive and negative attitudes towards AI and its use (e.g. Darda, Carre, and Cross 2023), these were considered separately in the present research.

It was hypothesized that attitudes towards academic misconduct, subjective norms about academic misconduct and perceived behavioral control over engaging in academic misconduct would be positively associated with student intentions to engage in academic misconduct facilitated by GAITs (H1). Furthermore, positive, but not negative, attitudes towards AI were expected to be associated with greater intention among students to engage in academic misconduct facilitated by GAITs (H2). Finally, it was anticipated that higher perceived likelihood of detection would be negatively associated with the intention to commit such acts (H3).

Method

Participants

The final sample consisted of 186 undergraduate university students (126 females; 57 males; 2 non-binary; 1 preferring not to say; age range 17–48 years, $M = 19.98$, $SD = 4.37$). Participants were enrolled in a first-year psychology unit and participated in the study in exchange for course credit.

Missing data and excluded participants

A total of 204 students completed the survey. A conservative rejection criterion was used, leading to the exclusion of two student participants due to completion of less than 80% of the online survey (Buchanan and Scofield 2018). A further 14 students were excluded for failing an attention check item, while two more participants were excluded for not responding to this item. Of the remaining 186 participants, there was very little missing data at the individual item level (0.13%). Little's Missing Completely at Random (MCAR) test was conducted using IBM SPSS Statistics and revealed these data were missing completely at random ($p = .549$). Single imputation through expectation-maximisation was performed prior to analyses to account for these missing values (Schafer and Graham 2002).

Measures

Intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs

An 8-item measure adapted from Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore (2010) was administered to assess intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs. The original scale assesses intention to engage in behaviors such as cheating and plagiarism. For the present study, item wording was modified to explicitly reference the use of GAITs, as no other existing measure was fit for purpose at the time of the current research. No

changes were made to item structure, response format, or underlying construct. Participants rated their level of likelihood of engaging in a given behavior on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (*very unlikely*) to 5 (*very likely*), e.g. ‘*How likely are you to consider turning in work generated by GAITs as one’s own?*’. An overall mean was calculated, with higher scores representing greater intent to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs. The resultant scale demonstrated excellent internal consistency ($\alpha = .93$).

Attitudes towards academic misconduct

A 13-item self-report measure of attitudes towards academic misconduct was adapted from Maring et al. (2018), a measure originally designed for health professional students. As no other available measure was identified and deemed suitable for the present study, items were reworded to reflect academic misconduct within broader university contexts, e.g. ‘*A culture of cheating is prevalent in university*’. Participants rated their level of agreement with each statement on a 5-point Likert scale of 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*). An overall mean was calculated, with higher scores representing more accepting attitudes towards academic misconduct. Moderate internal consistency for this scale was found in the present study ($\alpha = .75$).

Subjective norms

An 8-item subscale from the Perceptions and Attitudes towards Cheating among Engineering Students Survey (PACES-2) was administered to assess subjective norms about academic misconduct (Harding et al. 2007). Participants rated their agreement with each statement on a 5-point Likert scale from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*), e.g. ‘*People whose opinions I value (e.g. my family, friends, colleagues, teachers, etc.) expect me to cheat on an in-class test or exam*’. An overall mean was calculated, with higher scores representing greater positive subjective norms about academic misconduct. High internal consistency was demonstrated in this study ($\alpha = .84$).

Perceived behavioral control

A 4-item measure was administered to assess perceived behavioral control over engaging in academic misconduct (Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2010). Participants rated their level of agreement on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*), e.g. ‘*If I wanted to cheat on exams it would be easy*’. An overall mean was calculated, with higher scores representing greater perceived ease of engaging in academic misconduct. Adequate internal consistency was demonstrated in the present study ($\alpha = .68$).

Attitudes towards AI

The 20-item General Attitudes towards Artificial Intelligence Scale (GAAIS) (Schepman and Rodway 2020) was administered to assess attitudes towards AI. The scale has two subscales: positive, reflecting AI benefits (e.g. ‘*Artificial Intelligence is exciting*’), and negative, reflecting AI disadvantages (e.g. ‘*I find Artificial Intelligence sinister*’), as well as one attention check item (e.g. ‘*Please choose Strongly Agree to show that you have read this statement*’). The attention check item was modified for clarity in accordance with author recommendation (A. Schepman, personal communication, March 29, 2023). Participants rated their level of agreement with each statement on a 5-point Likert scale from

1 (*strongly disagree*) to 5 (*strongly agree*). Mean subscale scores were calculated from items reflecting positive attitudes and items reflecting negative attitudes. An overall scale mean was not calculated due to construct dimensionality. In this study, the GAAIS demonstrated high internal consistency for the positive ($\alpha = .83$) and moderate internal consistency for the negative ($\alpha = .75$) subscales.

Perceived likelihood of detection

At the time of study design, no brief psychometrically validated instruments measuring perceived likelihood of detection for GAIT-related academic misconduct were available. Therefore, two items were purpose-created, informed by prior academic misconduct research. More specifically, the authors drew on Megehee and Spake (2008), who assessed probable detection using multiple behavior-specific single items that were combined into a composite score, and McCabe, Trevino, and Butterfield (2002), which examined perceived certainty of being caught using single-item indicators. Consistent with these approaches, two items to capture perceived likelihood of detection for self and peers when using GAITs were developed for the current study (*‘How likely do you think it is you would be detected if you use GAITs to complete an assignment or exam?’* and *‘How likely do you think it is your peers would be detected if they use GAITs to complete an assignment or exam?’*). Item clarity and face validity were assessed through internal review prior to data collection. Participants rated the likelihood of the two situations on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1 (*very unlikely*) to 5 (*very likely*). The two items were strongly correlated, suggesting that they reflected a similar underlying construct, leading to the calculation of an average composite score. Higher scores represented greater perceived likelihood of GAIT detection. This scale demonstrated adequate internal consistency ($r = .74$).

Social desirability

The 16-item Behavior in Desirable Responding Scale (BIDR-16) was used to measure social desirability (Hart et al. 2015). The scale measures two factors: Self-deceptive enhancement (e.g. *‘I never regret my decisions’*) and impression management (e.g. *‘I never cover up my mistakes’*). Participants rated their level of agreement with each statement on an 8-point Likert scale of 1 (*totally disagree*) to 8 (*totally agree*). An overall score was calculated by scoring one point for every response of 7 or 8 on a statement, with higher scores representing greater tendencies for socially desirable scoring. Internal consistency was moderate for the BIDR-16 ($\alpha = .77$).

Procedure

The study was granted ethics approval by the institutional Human Research Ethics Committee (Reference Number: 520231313949982). Participants were given information about the study and provided informed consent for their participation prior to the administration of a 30-minute online questionnaire via the Qualtrics survey platform. Basic demographic information, such as participant age and gender were collected, following which participants completed study measures.

Results

Data analytic strategy

All statistical analyses were conducted using IBM SPSS Statistics (Version 29). The nominal alpha was set at .05 for all significance testing. In terms of assumption testing, independence was met through study design. The normality of residuals was confirmed through observation of a normal probability plot and a Shapiro–Wilk test for normality ($p = .39$). Variance inflation factor values were also inspected and evidence of multicollinearity not found. However, an examination of a scatterplot of residuals against predicted values revealed both fanning and non-linear patterns, suggesting the assumptions of linearity and homoscedasticity of residuals were violated. Consequently, bootstrapping with 5000 replications was utilized for relevant analyses (Banjanovic and Osborne 2019; Field and Wilcox 2017). Results are presented in two parts. First, descriptive statistics and Pearson correlations between all study variables to examine bivariate relationships are shown. Secondly, a hierarchical linear regression examining factors associated with the intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITS is described.

Bivariate correlations and descriptive statistics

Table 1 displays the bivariate Pearson correlations and descriptive statistics for all variables included in the current study. All factors, excluding the negative subscale of the measure assessing attitudes towards AI, were correlated with intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITS. Correlations were positive, except for perceived likelihood of detection of GAIT use, for which a negative association with intention to engage in such misconduct was yielded.

Hierarchical linear regression

A bootstrapped hierarchical linear regression was conducted to investigate factors associated with intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITS (see Table 2). The first model consisted of a single control variable: social desirability. The model accounted for a significant degree of variance in intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITS, $F(1, 184) = 23.11$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .11$. The second model added the three TPB constructs: attitudes towards academic misconduct, subjective norms about academic

Table 1. Bivariate pearson correlations and descriptive statistics for study variables.

Variable	<i>M</i>	<i>SD</i>	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8
1. Intention	1.84	0.77	—							
2. Attitudes	3.04	0.5	.53**	—						
3. Subjective norms	2.12	0.59	.49**	.55**	—					
4. Perceived behavioral control	2.33	0.67	.30**	.31**	.23*	—				
5. Likelihood of detection	3.81	0.86	−.29**	.16*	.32**	−.29**	—			
6. Positive attitudes Towards AI	3.18	0.56	.29**	.16*	.21*	.17*	−.14	—		
7. Negative attitudes towards AI	2.72	0.58	.05	.04	.10	−.00	−.10	.37**	—	
8. Social desirability	2.96	2.57	−.33**	−.30**	−.26**	−.07	−.07	−.04	−.08	—

Note: $N = 186$.

* $p < .05$, ** $p < .001$.

Table 2. Bootstrapped hierarchical linear regression.

Variables	R^2	ΔR^2	B^a	$SE(B)^a$	β	t	p -value	95% CI [LL, UL]
Model 1	.11						<.001***	
Social desirability			-.10	.02	-.33	-4.81	<.001***	[-.13, -.07]
Model 2	.38	.26					<.001***	
Social desirability			-.05	.02	-.17	-2.75	.005**	[-.09, -.02]
Attitudes			.45	.11	.29	3.95	<.001***	[.23, .66]
Subjective norms			.33	.09	.25	3.52	<.001***	[.15, .51]
Perceived behavioral control			.16	.07	.14	2.29	.026*	[.02, .31]
Model 3	.42	.05					.003*	
Social desirability			-.05	.02	-.18	-2.99	.004**	[-.09, -.02]
Attitudes			.45	.11	.29	4.07	<.001***	[.23, .66]
Subjective norms			.25	.10	.19	2.60	.015*	[.04, .44]
Perceived behavioral control			.10	.08	.08	1.34	.199	[-.06, .24]
Likelihood of detection			-.11	.06	-.13	-2.03	.037*	[-.23, -.01]
Attitudes towards AI								
Positive			.28	.08	.20	3.19	.002**	[.12, .43]
Negative			-.11	.08	-.08	-1.35	.137	[-.26, .04]

Notes: ^aEstimates from bootstrapped analysis. $N = 186$. $\Delta R^2 = R^2$ change; B = unstandardized coefficient; $SE(B)$ = standard error; CI = confidence interval; LL = lower limit; UL = upper limit.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

misconduct and perceived behavioral control over engaging in academic misconduct. This model was also significant and accounted for a further 26% of the variance in intentions, $F(4, 181) = 27.16$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .38$. The third model introduced three more predictors: positive and negative attitudes towards AI and perceived likelihood of detection. This model was also significant and accounted for 4.7% further variance in intentions than the variables included in the previous model, $F(7, 178) = 18.59$, $p < .001$, $R^2 = .42$.

Partially consistent with H1, attitudes towards academic misconduct and subjective norms about academic misconduct were related to greater intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs. However, perceived behavioral control was not associated with intentions. The results supported H2, such that positive, but not negative, attitudes towards AI yielded a positive association with intentions for academic misconduct using GAITs. Finally, consistent with H3, higher perceived likelihood of detection was negatively associated with intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs.

Discussion

The primary aim of the current study was to investigate associations between intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs and predictors of behavioral intention as per Ajzen's (1991) TPB model (attitudes, subjective norms, and perceived behavioral control). A secondary aim of the study was to expand this model to include the exploration of relations between student intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs and two additional factors; namely, attitudes towards AI and perceived likelihood of detection. Considering the implications of academic misconduct for students and institutions alike (Abdolmohammadi and Baker 2007; Martinson, Anderson, and de Vries 2005; Parnter 2022), it was envisaged the results of this research would inform education policies and interventions, and ultimately contribute to the emerging field of research in authentic assessment in higher education in the AI era.

The TPB model and intentions to engage in academic misconduct using gaits

Partial support for H1 was obtained, such that greater positive attitudes towards academic misconduct, as well as greater subjective norms about academic misconduct, were associated with greater intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs. These findings accord with literature demonstrating a relationship between attitudes towards and subjective norms about traditional forms of academic misconduct and intention to engage in such academic misconduct (Alleyne and Phillips 2011; Cronan, Mullins, and Douglas 2018; Harding et al. 2007; Juan et al. 2022; Maloshonok and Shmeleva 2019; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2009). Interestingly, consistent with the findings of Hendy and Montargot (2019), albeit in the context of more traditional forms of academic misconduct, attitudes towards academic misconduct using GAITs yielded the strongest association with intentions to engage in academic misconduct, compared to the other constructs comprising the TPB model.

It thus follows when it comes to institutional policies and intervention strategies designed to encourage behaviors aligning with academic integrity, institutions may be best to understand the subjective norms relating to academic misconduct using GAITs at their respective institution, and then seeking to address these accordingly. Furthermore, in what is perhaps an encouraging insight for the field, while violations of academic conduct remain highly ubiquitous (M. J. Birks et al. 2018; M. Birks et al. 2020; Curtis and Popal 2011), and perhaps even more so with the advent of generative-AI technologies, the current findings suggest the higher education student's decision to engage in academic misconduct is likely impacted by perceived subjective norms about the engagement of such acts, beyond frequency of engagement across peers alone, which is arguably more amenable to intervention.

In opposition to H1, perceived behavioral control and intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs were not related in the final model inclusive of attitudes towards AI and perceived likelihood of detection of AI use. Notably, in the previous model omitting these auxiliary factors, the relationship between perceived behavioral control and intentions was significant. Multicollinearity was disconfirmed via an inspection of variance inflation factor values, and accords with the magnitude of correlations observed between these factors. Instead, these findings implicate these auxiliary factors as perhaps the mechanism of influence between behavioral control and intention found in previous studies. An examination of the literature suggests likelihood of detection may be particularly relevant. Ajzen, in his 2002 paper seeking to clarify conceptual and methodological ambiguities surrounding the concept of perceived behavioral control, emphasized that control beliefs – defined as beliefs that may further or hinder performance of the behavior – give rise to perceived behavioral control. It is highly plausible that perceptions of the likelihood of GAIT detection would hinder academic misconduct using GAITs. This proposed interplay between perceptions of behavioral control, perceived likelihood of detection, and intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs warrants further exploration.

Beyond the TPB model: attitudes towards AI and perceived likelihood of detection

The current findings suggest reasonable applicability of the TPB to intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs. The exploration of auxiliary factors that may

enhance understanding of student intention to engage in academic misconduct is considered commonplace (e.g. Imran, Hussien, and Alaraimi 2025; Rajah-Kanagasabai and Roberts 2015; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2010). In this study, the addition of attitudes towards AI and perceived likelihood of GAIT detection contributed to variance in intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs, over and above the inclusion of constructs derived from the TPB (Ajzen 1991).

Consistent with H2, an association between the positive subscale of the GAAIS and greater intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs was found, while no relationship was present for negative attitudes towards AI. These findings align with prior research suggesting those with positive attitudes towards AI are more likely to adopt AI (Darda, Carre, and Cross 2023; Lambert et al. 2023; Schepman and Rodway 2020). That student attitudes regarding the drawbacks of AI do not seem related to intentions to use GAITs for the purposes of committing academic misconduct is especially noteworthy for higher education providers. Possibly, students acknowledge the drawbacks of AI, but do not prioritize these over the perceived benefits. This suggests institutional policies and intervention strategies focused on highlighting the potential negative implications of AI for students in terms of the attainment of graduate capabilities may be misguided (Bobula 2024); rather, fostering among students a mindset where GAITs are viewed as supplemental, as opposed to, replacements for their knowledge and skills (Ardito 2025; L. Bennett and Abu-salem 2024), may be more advisable. It is however worth noting that while most contemporary universities have sought to proactively embrace GAITs in this way, establishing guidelines regarding acceptable and unacceptable use for students, considerable concerns exist regarding mere advocacy for the implementation of AI in education, given understanding about the appropriate use and risks of AI in academic settings remains in its infancy (Chan 2023). This inevitably raises questions about the efficacy of current methods for addressing the challenges posed by GAITs in educational settings.

In support of H3, higher perceived likelihood of detection was related to lower intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs. This suggests that the perceived risk of being detected acts as a deterrent for students who intend to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs (de Lambert, Ellen, and Taylor 2006; Makarova 2019; McCabe, Trevino, and Butterfield 2002). Aligning with economic theory, students may weigh the consequences of detection to be greater than the benefits gained from using GAITs for academic misconduct (Megehee and Spake 2008). Unfortunately for higher education providers, current research casts significant doubt over the accuracy and reliability of even state-of-the art AI-detection tools (Ardito 2025; Weber-Wulff et al. 2023), with findings that no doubt serve to reduce perceptions of the likelihood of detection for the savvy university student. Perceived challenges detecting the use of GAITs may thus bolster its improper use among higher education students who, recognizing the limitations in AI-generated text detection in tertiary institutions, may possess diminished fear of detection (Dalalah and Dalalah 2023; McCabe, Trevino, and Butterfield 2001). This can create a contagion effect that encourages non-engaging students who feel disadvantaged to do the same (Megehee and Spake 2008; Sattler, Wiegel, and Veen 2017). In response, universities could consider alternative detection methods to human identification, including the integration of AI-based detection technologies (Chaka 2023; Weber-Wulff et al. 2023). Though these authors would contend the likelihood of developing robust AI-detection tools that effectively leverages AI itself in the battle against AI seems unlikely.

Indeed, it appears there is no ‘easy solution’ for improving AI-detection (Weber-Wulff et al. 2023). Such circumstances may serve to reduce both the self-efficacy and inclination of educators to identify and report suspected cases of academic misconduct using GAITs, seeing these efforts as perhaps futile in the current climate or unsupported by university administrators. Paradoxically, it follows logically that where a strong commitment to reporting instances of academic misconduct using GAITs exists, perceptions of the likelihood that one might be detected if engaging in such behaviors should also increase, which, according to the results of this study, may serve to curtail intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs. Drawing on research regarding peer-to-peer whistleblowing when it comes to breaches of academic integrity (e.g. Amin et al. 2024), future investigations would benefit from better understanding factors that might support and empower potentially disenfranchised members of academic faculty to adopt a culture of identification when it comes to unauthorized GAIT use by students.

Strengths and limitations

A strength of the present study was the inclusion of social desirability as a control variable. While previous literature has recognized biased responding in self-report data (Imran, Hussien, and Alaraimi 2025; Juan et al. 2022; Stone, Jawahar, and Kisamore 2009), few studies have accounted for it. That social desirability was strongly associated with intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs highlights the importance that studies in this domain similarly seek to address this issue in their research, preferably using creative and more robust methods than afforded by the use of self-report measures alone.

The present study possessed several limitations. Firstly, due to the cross-sectional study design, causal relationships could not be established. Furthermore, the sample consisted primarily of females. While not a factor of interest in this study, research has reported gender differences in engagement in misconduct (K. K. Bennett, Behrendt, and Boothby 2011; Zhang, Yin, and Zheng 2018). Given 58% of the variance in intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs remained unaccounted for in this study, future research would benefit from considering whether gender, alongside a range of other variables, can boost the explanatory power of such models. It is also worth noting potential restrictions to the generalisability of the current results given the participant sample, which consisted solely of students enrolled in a first-year psychology unit of study and at a single university. It is further possible the conduct of a study investigating intentions to engage in academic misconduct within a tertiary setting may have biased the participant pool, despite assurances of anonymity and confidentiality having been provided to prospective participants. Finally, though the predictive relationship between behavioral intention and the actual conduct of that behavior remains the bedrock of the TPB (Ajzen 1991), whether intentions to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs precipitated actual academic integrity infringements was untested in this study.

Implications and conclusions

The current findings convey important implications for the development of policy and intervention in relation to breaches of academic integrity through the unauthorized use of GAITs as tertiary institutions continue moving towards meaningful and ethical

integration of such technologies in learning and assessment practice. Indeed, a number of commonsense solutions have already been offered in the literature with respect to combating improper GAIT use in higher education. These include but are not limited to the implementation of robust assessment strategies (e.g. Ardito 2025), improving AI-literacy (Russell Group 2023), and adopting a programmatic approach to assessment (Luo (Jess) 2024; The Tertiary Education Quality and Standards Agency 2023). Reducing tendencies towards over-assessment, which is known to impact student success (Yu et al. 2023), and thus perhaps increases pressure to use by fueling positive attitudes towards AI, may also prove effective.

However, what these findings principally highlight is that in developing sound academic integrity policies and assessment strategies, higher education providers would benefit from seeking to first understand their student bodies with respect to positive attitudes regarding academic misconduct and AI, subjective norms surrounding the use of GAITs in academic misconduct, and perceived likelihood of detection if using GAITs for these purposes. Shown in this study to be associated with the intention to engage in academic misconduct using GAITs, educational institutions should focus on tailoring interventions that proactively target these factors. This includes education programs emphasizing AI ethics to encourage responsible and conscientious use of GAITs. Addressing positive attitudes towards academic misconduct using GAITs through strategies that motivate and encourage the learner to authentically engage in the learning process, in spite of the ubiquitous availability of GAITs, in support of competency attainment, and in turn, graduate employability outcomes, also seems important. Efforts should further be made to challenge perceptions of the acceptability of academic misconduct using GAITs, as well as warn students about the possibility of detection and related consequences. Adopting an integrated, but targeted, intervention strategy addressing such factors may serve to effectively reduce engagement in academic misconduct using GAITs within higher education settings.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Data availability statement

Please note pursuant to the terms for ethics clearance, data for this study is not available via an open access repository. Interested parties are encouraged to contact the corresponding author for more information.

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